this scale, and not one so clearly traced back to Pakistan. That awful three-letter acronym, ISI, made its appearance and has haunted us since. Gangster Dawood Ibrahim rose from an amusing presence at Sharjah cricket stadiums to India's villain number one, and continues to be so.

Rajiv Gandhi's instinctive disapproval of the Mandal Commission report in 1985 sparked a backward caste awakening. Then a series of errors with communal implications—reversal of the Shah Bano judgment, ban on Salman Rushdie's *Midnight's Children*, unlocking the temple site in Ayodhya. Thereafter, our politics has been a contest between two contrasting ideas. Can you use caste to divide what religion united, or employ religion to reunite what caste divided? Whoever wins, rules India. Simply put, it is Mandir versus Mandal. The Mandal (caste) side had its 25-year epoch from 1989 to 2014. Until Narendra Modi reversed the equation in 2014. Now is the era of mandir (Hindutva) and it doesn't seem to have a half-life of any less than 25 years. The issue is still Mandir versus Mandal. It just played out in Bihar, as it will in Uttar Pradesh in 2027. This decade's redefinition of national politics has been the most durable in our history. The same applies to political economy. Thirty five years after the reform-led boom, fears and doubts over opening up continue even as we celebrate our successes.

The strength and the beauty of INDIA TODAY, the institution, draws from what a fair, opportunity-laden meritocracy it evolved into. It was unforgiving always, even brutal sometimes. But if you had the hunger, diligence, talent and also a thick skin, nothing—and nobody—could stop you from growing.

When I came into the magazine in 1983 after covering the Northeast, I was warned it is a "five-star" newsroom where unsophisticated Hindi Medium Types (HMTs) would be severely judged and discarded. But INDIA TODAY evolved. My first cover story for INDIA TODAY, by the way, was on Sunil Gavaskar after he scored his 29th hundred to equal Donald Bradman. I had never done any long-form sports writing. It is just that Aroon Purie and Suman Dubey (managing editor then) thought I was the most excited. T.N. Ninan says the INDIA TODAY newsroom of that era was the dream team of Indian journalism. Proof of the pudding lies in Google. Look at the masthead of that decade and see where we have reached.

While a clinical meritocracy was key to this, there was also a concept INDIA TODAY pioneered: the reporter-editor. It wasn't limited to a reporter rising to be an editor. Nothing at INDIA TODAY would be so simple. It also meant that even after becoming an editor, you would continue reporting, never mind your multiple editorial responsibilities.

Here's an example of how we were taught to multi-task. This decade saw INDIA TODAY launch its five language editions (Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Gujarati), which I was asked to helm from 1991 on, in addition to all my other responsibilities and writing. Sometimes, we were exhausted and wished Aroon would acknowledge that. But he wouldn't. After anchoring an 18-page cover story on the fatwa against Salman Rushdie with a football-team byline from across the world over two unslept nights, I sat on the news desk swinging my legs sort of smug in satisfaction as Aroon passed by. Tell him not to work so hard, Aroon, he will die, said then news coordinator Sandhya Mulchandani hoping Aroon would acknowledge it. He just said, "Hard work never killed anybody," and walked on.


SPECIAL REPORT

The Caste Crunch

Despite denials by agitation leaders the bitter of available evidence pointed the finger at them, though it was more a case of unintended aberrant than outright felony.

INDIA TODAY, *Apr. 15, 1985*

THE FIRST STORY I WROTE ON ONE OF THESE DESKTOPS WAS OF A MANDAL COMMISSION REPORT CONTROVERSY IN 1985. THAT STORY STILL ENDURES

At which point, finally, I list the three most important lessons that stay with me:

- There is always the other side to a story. Unless you have checked with that 'other' side, no story is publishable. This is non-negotiable. And if somebody complains about a story having been unfair to them, as editor, your default position is on their side. Until your facts check out.
- Anything that comes for free or easy, is loaded with evil. Just say no, or disclose and check.
- And third, be unselfconscious of identity in the work place. No discrimination, victimisation, exploitation or favouritism based on gender, ethnicity, caste, religion, anything. There's enough opportunity in this wonderfully meritocratic newsroom. Compete fairly and it will work to everybody's benefit. In this manner, too, INDIA TODAY was institutionally prescient. It was ahead of the new middle class consciousness for competitive equality that reform and growth brought in subsequently.

Having joined in 1983, I left in 1995, just as the decade concluded. If, out of the dozen-plus history-defining stories I listed at the outset, I got a piece of all but one—economic reform—I'd say it was a decade's life well lived. Especially in an Aristotelian sense. ■

Shekhar Gupta *was Executive Editor and an integral part of the* INDIA TODAY *team from 1983 to 1995. He is founder and Editor-in-Chief of* The Print